A PERIODIC SCRUTINY

Over the years, several panels have sought to restructure and reform the DRDO. This is what they said

V. Ramagopal Rao Committee (2020)

Rao, a former director of IIT Delhi, headed a panel to overhaul the DRDO to meet "defence and battlefield needs". Its recommendations were never made public, and led to the closure of some laboratories

Parliamentary Standing Committee on Defence (2019)

Headed by former cabinet minister and BJP MP Jual Oram, it recommended a "complete revamp" of DRDO by involving the private sector and institutions like IITs. It suggested a level playing field for private industry, and tie-ups with foreign manufacturers to develop cutting-edge equipment

P. Rama Rao Committee (2008)

The panel suggested that DRDO concentrate only on "core technologies of strategic importance". It also advised decentralisation of DRDO management and the creation of a Board of Research for Advanced Defence Sciences (BRADS) on the lines of the DARPA of US. Led to the clubbing of 52 DRDO labs under seven clusters

A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Committee (1992–93)

An internal panel headed by then DRDO chairman A.P.J. Abdul Kalam formulated a 10-year plan to increase indigenisation in defence equipment from 30 per cent to 70 per cent by 2005

fence technologies, air independent propulsion (AIP), torpedoes, cruise missiles, unmanned aerial vehicles, airborne early warning and control (AEW&C) aircraft systems, gas turbine engines, advanced towed artillery gun system (ATAGS), radars and surface-to-air and anti-ship missiles.

Ajay Bhat, MoS defence, did admit in Parliament to a cost escalation in 12 projects but stressed that the increase should be seen as an "enhancement of the scope of the project". Such projects involve Tejas Mark-II LCA, Naval LCA, UAVs and ATAGS. Bhat added that steps are being taken to address the delays, including increased frequency of project reviews and greater involvement of the armed forces and production partners during the development process, among others.

In December 2022, in a report on the performance of the DRDO tabled in Parliament, the CAG expressed dismay that some mission mode projects "declared successful" had actually not achieved their objectives despite more than Rs 1,000 crore being spent over them. It added that some of these 'successful' projects were taken up again to plug the holes left behind and presented as new ones. The report presented a dispiriting picture: in 119 out of 178 DRDO projects, the time schedule could not be adhered to. In 49 cases, the additional time taken was over 100 per cent of the original time frame, with time extension sought on multiple occasions.

Echoing A.K. Singh, another top DRDO official acknowledges that due to a wide area of activity, defence scientists do not have a focused approach, which eventually leads to core projects becoming peripheral. The end result is that scientists get bogged down by numerous challenges.

For a focused approach that can deliver swift results, Lt Gen. Hooda emphasises the "need to harness and synergise efforts of the DRDO, DPSUs (Defence Public Sector Undertakings) R&D centres, private sector R&D centres and academia". This will require a change in culture, and this has to be pushed by the government, he adds. However, he believes that while it's not easy for the DRDO to fully replicate the US's DARPA, its basic principles can be adopted. Under the DARPA model, there is regular churning of officials, which is good for injecting fresh ideas, says Lt Gen. Hooda. "To my understanding, there is not much difference in DARPA and DRDO in terms of budget. But a majority of DRDO's budget goes into paying salaries and the day-to-day running of its laboratories," he says.

IN DEFENCE OF THE DRDO

The DRDO has been taken to task for project delays, but one cannot ignore the fact that as a proportion of the total defence outlay, the R&D budget came down from 6.4 per cent in 2018-19 to 5.1 per cent in 2023-24, a sizeable chunk of which goes into salaries and other expenses. The amount left for R&D activities—Rs 3,500 crore for the current year—is insufficient. A parliamentary standing committee in March 2023 found India's R&D spend to be far less than of other countries like China and the US, which spend 20 per cent and 12 per cent of their respective defence budgets on R&D. The committee recommended "appropriate and adequate funding for DRDO projects, keeping in mind...research-based technological advancements across the globe".

Ravi Gupta, a former DRDO scientist, claims that the import lobby in the government and armed forces has also damaged the reputation and morale of the DRDO scientists. "Besides this, bureaucrats want control over a specialised organisation like the DRDO," Gupta says, hinting at a plan in the MoD to separate the currently unified post of DRDO chairman and secretary, R&D.

DRDO officials also point to the insufficient manpower for R&D projects. They say that since 2001, DRDO has had the same number of personnel despite a sixfold increase in outlay and greater push towards indigenous research as part of 'Make in India'. In April 2010, the Manpower Planning Board (MPB) recommended the appointment of 4,966 personnel and the ministry of finance sanctioned 1,316 posts, of which 436 have been approved by its department of expenditure. The Cabinet Committee on Security will take a final call on the matter.

All stakeholders agree that the DRDO should focus on the latest technologies to meet the future requirements of the armed forces. For that, a robust R&D ecosystem must be created beyond the research agency. The VijayRaghavan panel's report should indicate the road forward. ■